

Native-Like Use of Modality and Attitude

C2 · Renan the Teacher — English Language Academy

1. BRIEF EXPLANATION

C2 modality goes beyond certainty/possibility to convey fine shades of tentativeness, concession, politeness and layered epistemic stance — how confident, cautious or diplomatic the speaker wants to sound.

- a) Subtle modal shading
- - Tentativeness/hedging: might, could, would seem to, it could be said that, one might argue.

It would seem that the strategy has largely failed. (softer, more diplomatic than "The strategy has failed")

- - Concession within modality: may/might + well (acknowledging a point is likely true, often before contrasting it): She might well be right, but I still have reservations.
- - Politeness distancing: would/could/might used to soften requests, suggestions or opinions, creating social distance and respect.

Might I suggest an alternative approach? (very formal/polite) vs. Can I suggest...? (neutral)

- b) Layered modality — combining more than one modal expression (typically a modal + a modal-like verb phrase such as "expected to," "supposed to," "meant to") to express a nuanced, sometimes ironic, stance on an obligation or expectation that itself involves uncertainty.

He might have been expected to apologize, but he never did. (= it would have been reasonable to expect an apology, though uncertainty/distance is baked in)

She should, in theory, have been informed beforehand.

- c) Epistemic stance markers — phrases that signal how the writer/speaker is framing their own certainty, common in academic and diplomatic register.

It is conceivable that... / There is reason to believe that... / One cannot rule out the possibility that... / It stands to reason that...

Native-like control means choosing the modal combination that matches exactly how certain, cautious, or polite you intend to sound — not just whether something is possible or necessary.

2. EXAMPLES

- 1. It would seem that the negotiations have reached a stalemate.
- 2. She might well be the most qualified candidate, but the panel remains

divided.

- 3. Might I suggest we revisit this proposal at a later date?
- 4. He might have been expected to resign after the scandal, yet he remains in office.
- 5. One cannot rule out the possibility that the results were affected by bias.
- 6. There is reason to believe that the original estimate was overly optimistic.
- 7. It could be argued that the reform, while well-intentioned, was poorly executed.
- 8. She should, in theory, have received the documents by now.
- 9. It stands to reason that costs would rise given the current shortages.
- 10. He may well have a point, but the timing of his objection is questionable.

3. COMMON MISTAKES

- 1. Incorrect: It would seem the strategy fails.

Correct: It would seem that the strategy has failed.

Why: This hedged structure typically requires "that" before the clause, and the verb tense should match the intended time frame (here, a completed failure).

- 2. Incorrect: She might well being right.

Correct: She might well be right.

Why: After "might well," use the bare infinitive ("be"), not the gerund.

- 3. Incorrect: He might have expected to apologize.

Correct: He might have been expected to apologize.

Why: "Be expected to" is a passive structure (others expected it of him); dropping "been" changes the meaning to "he expected himself."

- 4. Incorrect: It cannot rule out the possibility that costs will rise.

Correct: One cannot rule out the possibility that costs will rise.

Why: The impersonal subject here is "one" (or "we"), not "it" — "it" doesn't fit this fixed epistemic phrase.

- 5. Incorrect: Might I to suggest an alternative?

Correct: Might I suggest an alternative?

Why: After the inverted modal "Might I," use the bare infinitive directly, without "to."

4. EXERCISES

- A. Gap-fill (complete with the correct modal/epistemic phrase)

- 1. It would ____ (seem) that the plan has stalled entirely.
- 2. She might ____ (well) be correct, but I'd like more evidence.
- 3. ____ I suggest we postpone the decision until next week? (very formal request)
- 4. He ____ (might/expect) to know better, given his experience.
- 5. There is reason ____ (believe) the figures were manipulated.
- 6. It ____ (stand/reason) that demand would fall as prices rose.
- 7. One cannot ____ (rule out) the possibility of further delays.
- 8. She should, in theory, ____ (already/inform) of the changes.
- B. Rewrite / Transformation (rewrite each direct statement with the appropriate hedged/modal tone)
- 1. The results are wrong. (make it tentative/hedged)
- 2. Costs will definitely rise. (make it a cautious epistemic claim, not a certainty)
- 3. Can I suggest a different approach? (make it more formal/polite)
- 4. He should have apologized. (add a layer of distance — "might have been expected to")
- 5. Bias affected the results. (rewrite as a possibility that can't be excluded, using "one cannot rule out...")
- C. Error Correction
- 1. It would seem the negotiations collapse.
- 2. She might well being the best candidate.
- 3. He might have expect an apology from her.
- 4. It cannot rule out the possibility of a delay.
- 5. Might I to ask a question?
- 6. There is reason believe the data is flawed.
- D. Guided Production
- 1. Write one sentence using "It would seem that..." to hedge an opinion about current events.
- 2. Write one sentence using "might well" to concede a point before disagreeing with it.
- 3. Write one sentence using "One cannot rule out the possibility that..." about an uncertain outcome.
- 4. Write one very formal, polite request using inverted "Might I...?"

5. ANSWER KEY

- A. Gap-fill
- 1. seem
- 2. well
- 3. Might
- 4. might have been expected
- 5. to believe
- 6. stands to reason
- 7. rule out
- 8. have already been informed
- B. Rewrite / Transformation
- 1. It would seem that the results are incorrect.
- 2. There is reason to believe that costs will rise.
- 3. Might I suggest a different approach?
- 4. He might have been expected to apologize.
- 5. One cannot rule out the possibility that bias affected the results.
- C. Error Correction

- 1. It would seem that the negotiations have collapsed.
- 2. She might well be the best candidate.
- 3. He might have expected an apology from her.
- 4. One cannot rule out the possibility of a delay.
- 5. Might I ask a question?
- 6. There is reason to believe the data is flawed.
- D. Guided Production (sample answers)
- 1. It would seem that remote work has permanently changed employer expectations.
- 2. He might well be telling the truth, but I still think we should verify his story.
- 3. One cannot rule out the possibility that the delay will affect the entire launch schedule.
- 4. Might I ask you to reconsider your decision before the meeting concludes?

Renan the Teacher — English Language Academy ·
renangrossi.github.io/englishclasses